

Chapter 177-18

"I'd like a lily." Chen Mian said as she handed over her phone. "And your contact information."

Qi Jiao: "?"

She should have refused, but as if possessed, Qi Jiao entered her number.

When she saw Chen Mian's tears fall, she herself shed a tear as well.

Qi Jiao opened the door to the flower shop and asked her: "What's your name?"

Chen Mian paused briefly, then smiled in the morning sunlight: "Chen Mian."

The bookstore next door had just opened, and the song playing was "Flock of Lonely Birds."¹

Zhou Yi'an had drunk herself into a stupor. Su Meiqi helped her back to the room, then was so exhausted she lay on the floor unable to move. She simply lay on the carpet playing with her phone.

Before long, a mechanical voice suddenly rang in Zhou Yi'an's mind: 【Detection complete. You have an unresolved obsession in your body. The Obsession Management Bureau is activated. Do you wish to resolve your obsession? If you choose yes, you will be transported to another time and space to see the person you've always wanted to see. If you choose no, this memory will be erased.】

Zhou Yi'an was startled: "The person I've always wanted to see?"

Mechanical voice: 【Liang Shi.】

Zhou Yi'an asked: "Is she doing well now?"

Mechanical voice: 【Alive.】

Zhou Yi'an closed her eyes: "Can I see her?"

The mechanical voice thought for a moment. 【You can be given five minutes to go to that time and space. Within five minutes, you must make a choice. Otherwise, the space-time gate will close, and it will be assumed you want to stay in that time and space.】

Zhou Yi'an nodded: "Okay."

Then a flash of white light, and Zhou Yi'an appeared at the entrance of a kindergarten.

All around were parents dropping off their children for school. Zhou Yi'an standing there looked somewhat out of place.

The person with the exact same face as Liang Shi was standing at the kindergarten entrance, smiling and saying good morning to each child.

Very energetic.

Those eyes held no hostility, yet it was easy to recognize her as the Liang Shi she knew.

Zhou Yi'an stood in a corner watching her the whole time. After all the children had gone in, she also noticed Zhou Yi'an at the entrance. They gazed at each other from a distance.

She curved her lips into a light smile, as if taking Zhou Yi'an back many years.

"Do you know me?" She took the initiative to walk over and ask.

Zhou Yi'an nodded: "I think so."

Liang Shi frowned: "And then?"

Zhou Yi'an pressed her lips together: "Are you dating anyone?"

Liang Shi was taken aback: "Are you trying to date me?"

"No." Zhou Yi'an said. "I was just asking."

Time kept passing. Before the space-time gate closed, Zhou Yi'an suddenly heard a shrill cry: "Zhou Yi'an!"

Su Meiqi was crying again.

Zhou Yi'an stared at Liang Shi for a while, then waved at her. "Be a good person from now on. I'm leaving."

In the final choice, Zhou Yi'an chose to return to the original world.

But the Obsession Management Bureau didn't delete her memories—they only took away her obsession.

When Zhou Yi'an woke up, she found Su Meiqi hugging her and crying, tears falling onto her face again.

Zhou Yi'an wiped her face. "What are you wailing about?"

Su Meiqi was startled and immediately jumped up, dropping her head on the floor again: "I thought you were dead."

Zhou Yi'an's head took a critical hit. She slowly sat up, holding her head: "Even if I wasn't dead, you'd have killed me from the fall."

"You just fell off the bed and didn't react at all." Su Meiqi was scared to death.

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Don't cry over nothing." Zhou Yi'an said. "It's too ugly."

Su Meiqi kicked her. "Do you even know how to talk?"

Zhou Yi'an leaned against the bed, thinking about the person she had just seen. What did she choose in the end?

She still chose this side.

Zhou Yi'an looked up at Su Meiqi—still that lively, bouncy little girl.

She gently closed her eyes, listening to Su Meiqi chattering in her ear.

She didn't find it annoying.

It seemed to have started when she was a teenager.

But what was Zhou Yi'an doing back then?

She seemed to have been thinking about how to destroy the world.

If there was someone who could be like her, that would have been more than she could ask for.

But now, Zhou Yi'an seemed to want to be a good person.

She couldn't quite say whether it was better to destroy the world with someone or to be a good person for someone.

But... she had already made her choice.

"Zhou Yi'an, are you even listening to me?" Su Meiqi shook her arm.

Zhou Yi'an opened her eyes carelessly. "Not even calling me 'jie' anymore?"

"I'm not calling you that. Zhou Yi'an, Zhou Yi'an." Su Meiqi continued to fool around.

Zhou Yi'an climbed onto the bed. "Suit yourself."

After Liang Shi finished washing up and returned to the room, she found Xu Qingzhu lying over the table writing something. When she went over, Xu Qingzhu suddenly put it away.

Liang Shi asked while drying her hair: "What are you writing?"

"A secret." Xu Qingzhu said as she tossed the card into a drawer, then went to blow-dry her hair. As she left, she reminded her: "No peeking."

Liang Shi glanced at her retreating figure. After she finished her skincare routine sitting there, she still didn't open the drawer to look.

After a while, when Xu Qingzhu came back, Liang Shi finally said: "Did you see Chen Mian tonight?"

"Chen Mian? Who's that?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "?"

Afterward, Liang Shi asked Zhao Xuning and Gu Yixue on her phone. None of them remembered Chen Mian.

Chen Mian had disappeared from this world, but in another world, she had met her beloved.

Here, only Liang Shi still remembered Chen Mian.

But that was also a good thing.

In the end, Liang Shi couldn't resist. While Xu Qingzhu went to the bathroom, she secretly took out that card.

What Xu Qingzhu had written on it was for her.

Liang Shi, this world is cruel, but you are wonderful.

You deserve to be loved by everyone.

Baby, happy wedding.

I love you.

After reading it, Liang Shi felt her heart swell with bittersweet emotion. Happiness was about to overflow. When Xu Qingzhu came out of the bathroom, she immediately went over and hugged her like a koala.

"What?" Xu Qingzhu pushed her.

Liang Shi waved the card in her hand, then leaned in to kiss her: "Wife, I love you too."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly and responded with feigned indifference: "Oh."

Outside was the sound of waves crashing against the shore, the lighthouse in the distance over the sea, the city with its towering buildings, the world woven of light and shadow.

And lights turning on one by one.

In this vast city, there was always one light shining for Liang Shi.

If happiness lay ahead like the lights of countless homes, then all the hardships along the way had meaning.

The End.

Footnotes:

¹ "Flock of Lonely Birds" (孤鳥症群) - This appears to be the title of a song playing in the scene. The title evokes imagery of lonely birds finding their flock, symbolically reflecting Chen Mian finally finding Qi Jiao after all this time.